never been in an environment as weird and alien as that room: I just tried to concentrate on Victoria and put where I was out of my mind. She looked up:

‘I’m really hungry. Do you think you’ll be able to get me some smoked salmon?’

She’d been wolfing down the stuff all through the pregnancy—and I’m sure that’s why Brooklyn has always preferred fish to red meat—but I hadn’t expected her to get that kind of craving just then. I was waiting, watching. I could feel my heart beating away in my chest. And, all of a sudden, the mum was feeling peckish. The very next moment, our baby was there, held by a nurse in the air. I could see him; Victoria couldn’t at first. Because it was a caesarean, they had to put Brooklyn on a table and run a little tube into his mouth and nose to clear his airways. The nurse bundled him up in a terrycloth, as tight as you like, and passed him over to me. Because Victoria was still being stitched up at that point, I got to hold him first. I know it sounds selfish but it was such a privilege, such an amazing feeling. I’ve experienced it twice now, and nothing in my life, on a soccer field or anywhere else, comes close to the intensity of that moment: the thrill and the awe, holding your son in your arms for the very first time. I carried Brooklyn the few steps over to his mum and laid his head on the pillow next to hers: the two most precious people in the whole world, looking so much alike and so beautiful, too. That picture will be in my mind’s eye forever.

I’d always wanted to have children. Maybe it was growing up with a baby sister in the house. Maybe I’ve just got that paternal thing from my mum and dad, I don’t know. I can remember, when I broke into the United team, feeling jealous of the older players on the odd days during a season when they could bring their children in to training, to sit on the sidelines and watch Dad play. I wanted that really badly. And, I’ll be honest, I always wanted a son. Two sons, in fact: as much as I loved Joanne, I know—and she knows, we laugh about it—I always wanted a baby brother, too. That afternoon at the Portland, gazing down at Victoria nuzzled up against our newborn son, I knew that, whatever else had happened or was going to happen in my life, I’d been blessed.

I remember Victoria turning to me as I cradled Brooklyn in my arms:

‘Whatever you do, please don’t leave him.’

We’d had threats made to us since the summer and, again, just before Brooklyn was born. We’d talked about it all beforehand, how we were going to handle the security, and I went with the nurse when she took Brooklyn to